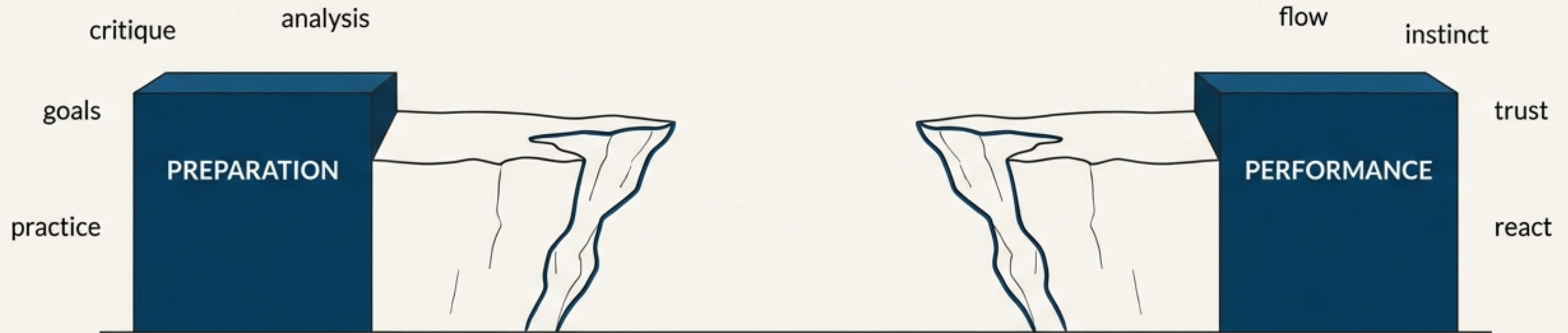




The Final Inch: Mastering the Pre-Performance Routine

How to Bridge the Gap
Between Confidence
and Execution

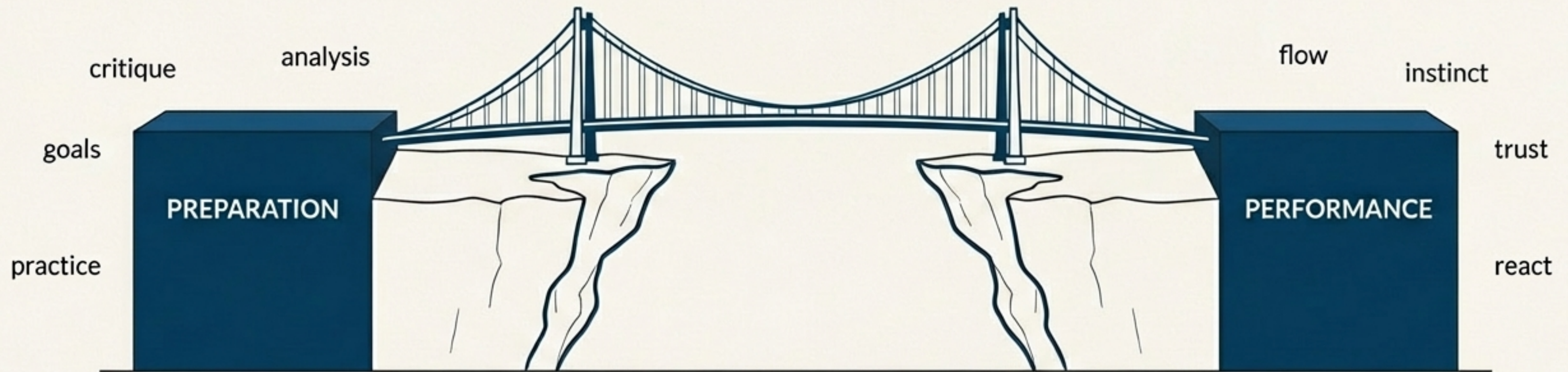
You've Built Unshakable Confidence. So Why Doesn't It Always Show Up?



Even the most prepared individuals face a critical gap between their known ability and their in-the-moment performance. Confidence, once achieved, is not automatic. This is the gap where the “sewer cycle” of worry begins, and analysis paralyzes instinct.

The mind can be dominated by thoughts of failure despite plenty of available success. The key is taking command of your thinking to selectively interpret experience, retaining what builds certainty while releasing what causes setbacks. — Dr. Nate Zinsser

The Routine Is the Bridge From a Thinking Mind to a Performing Body.



Focuses Attention: Performance planning strategies enhance concentration and readiness. Routines narrow the mind to the task at hand.



Reduces Anxiety: Routines provide a sense of familiarity and control, helping manage activation state and energy level.

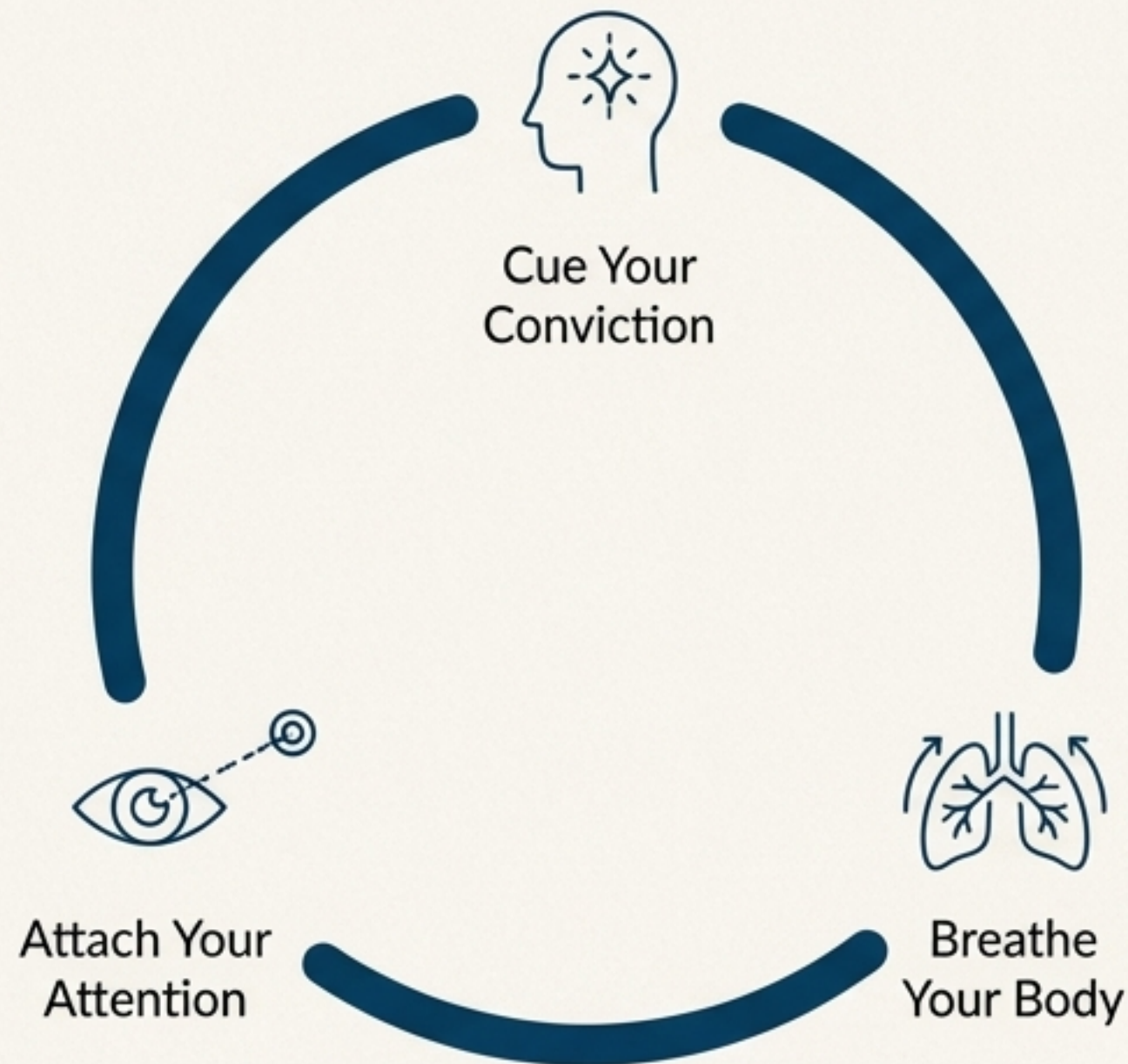


Eliminates Distractions: Structured pre-competition plans are critical for consistency and controlling the controllable.

'Developing competitive plans, and establishing routines' are proven techniques for enhancing concentration and developing attentional focus. — Weinberg & Gould, Foundations of Sport and Exercise Psychology

The Three-Step Ritual for On-Demand Performance

Developed by Dr. Nate Zinsser after decades of work with elite military, corporate, and athletic performers, the C-B-A routine is a simple, powerful sequence to consciously transition into a state of unconscious certainty.



1. **C**ue Your Conviction
2. **B**reathe Your Body
3. **A**ttach Your Attention

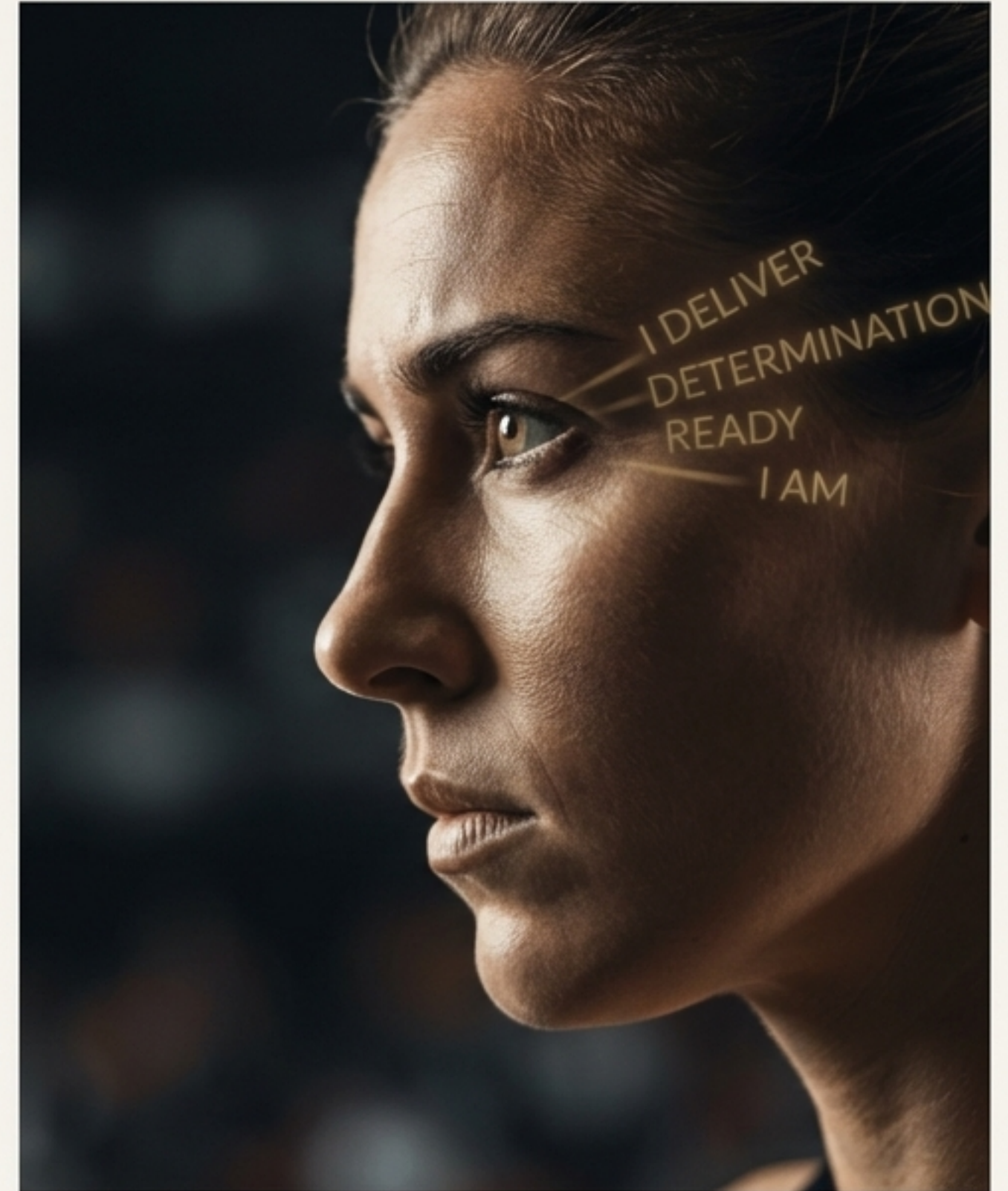
Step 1: CUE Your Conviction

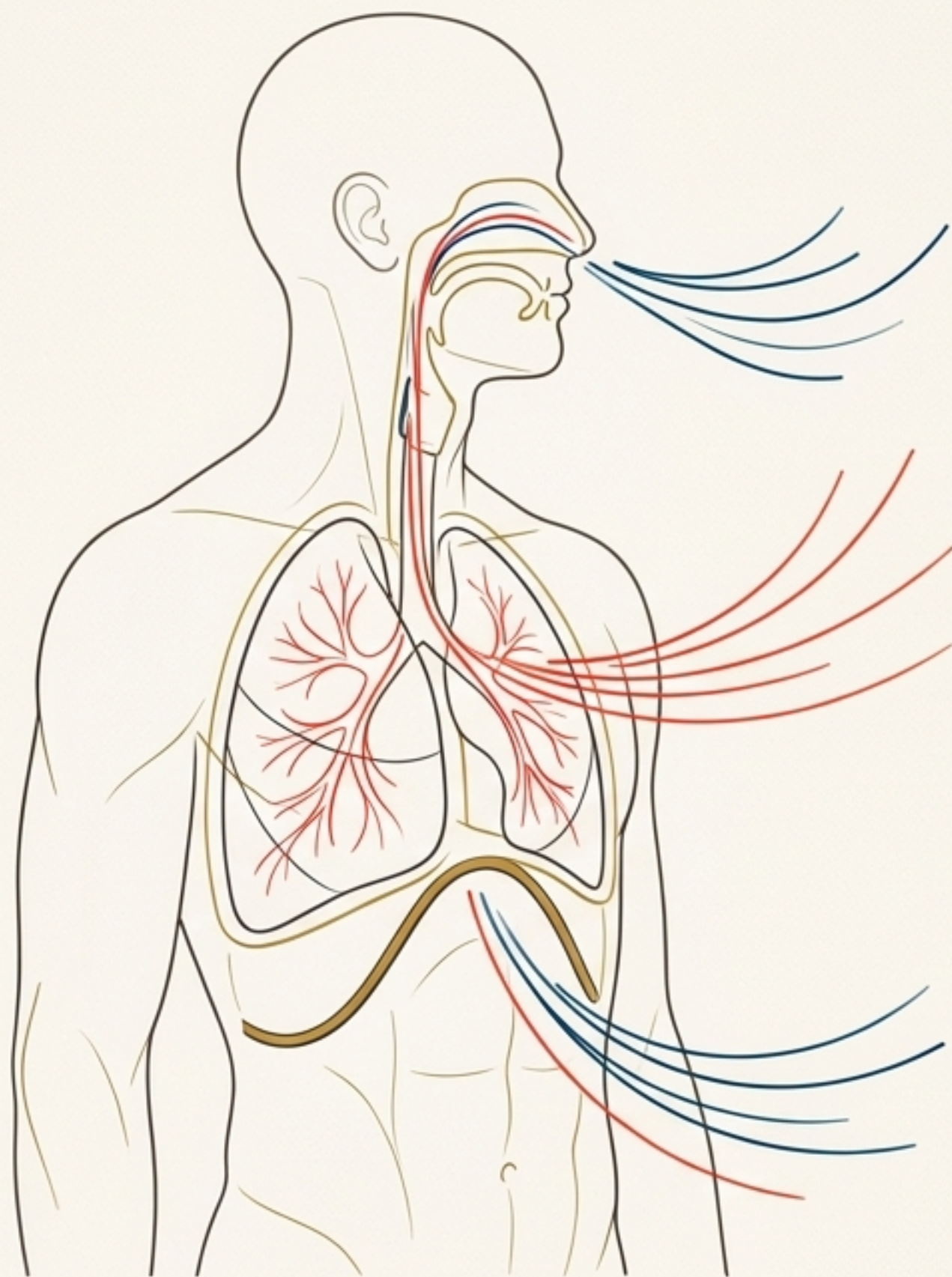
This is a mental trigger—a powerful, pre-selected affirmation that reminds you of who you are at your best. It's not a wish; it's a declaration phrased in the present tense. It makes your hard-won confidence, your 'mental bank account,' immediately accessible.

“He had won the victory in his heart and mind, which gave him the best chance to win on the field in the toughest conditions.”
— *Dr. Nate Zinsser on Eli Manning's First Victory*

Examples of Affirmations:

- **The Athlete:** “I am the player who delivers when the game is on the line.”
- **The Leader:** “I meet each new situation with determination and understanding.”





Step 2: **BREATHE** Your Body

Concept

A deep, controlled breath is the fastest way to interrupt the body's stress response. It signals to your autonomic nervous system that you are in control. This transforms "nervous energy" into "ready energy."

The Science

When you're about to perform, your brain signals the adrenal glands, which dump adrenaline into the bloodstream. This causes a racing heart, jittery muscles, and butterflies. This is your body tapping into high-octane fuel to help you perform.

- "Champions like Michael Johnson know that it won't feel normal when they step into the spotlight, and they look forward to that very feeling as a signal that something special is about to happen." ➤
— Dr. Nate Zinsser

Step 3: ATTACH Your Attention

Concept

This is the final act: shifting focus from your internal state (thoughts, feelings) to a specific, external target. This quiets the analytical mind and allows your trained instincts to take over. Your focus becomes singular and absolute.

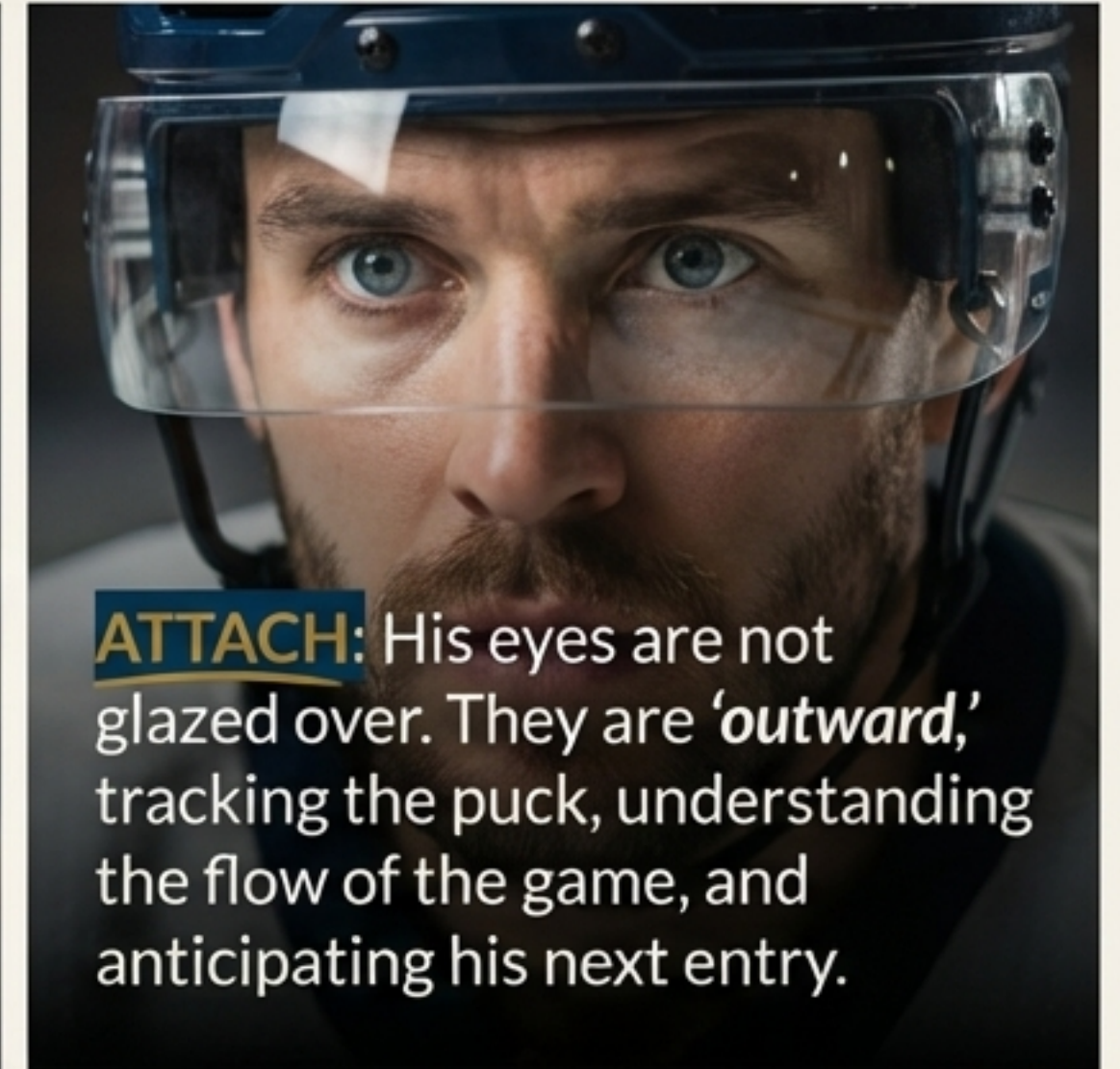
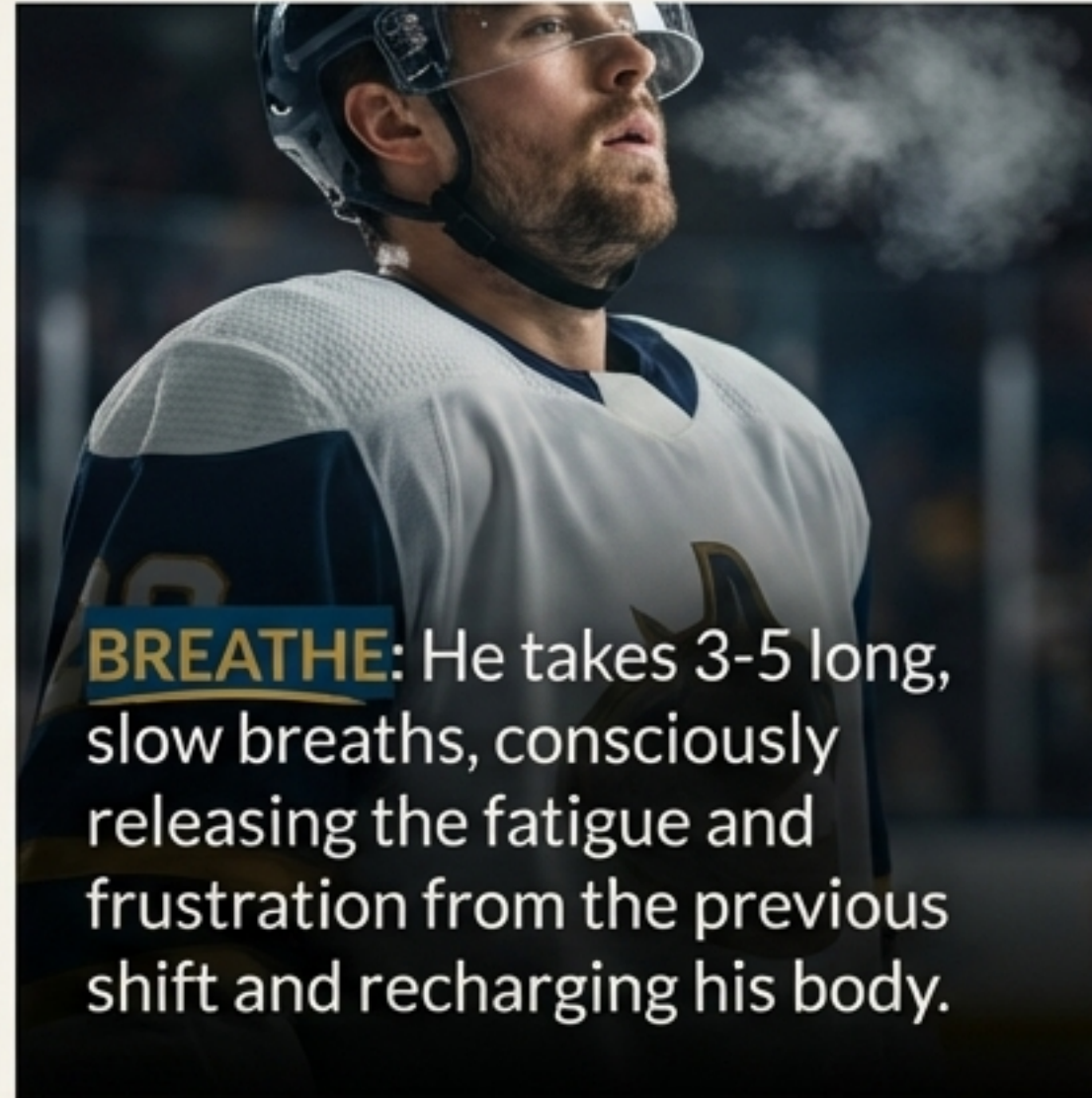
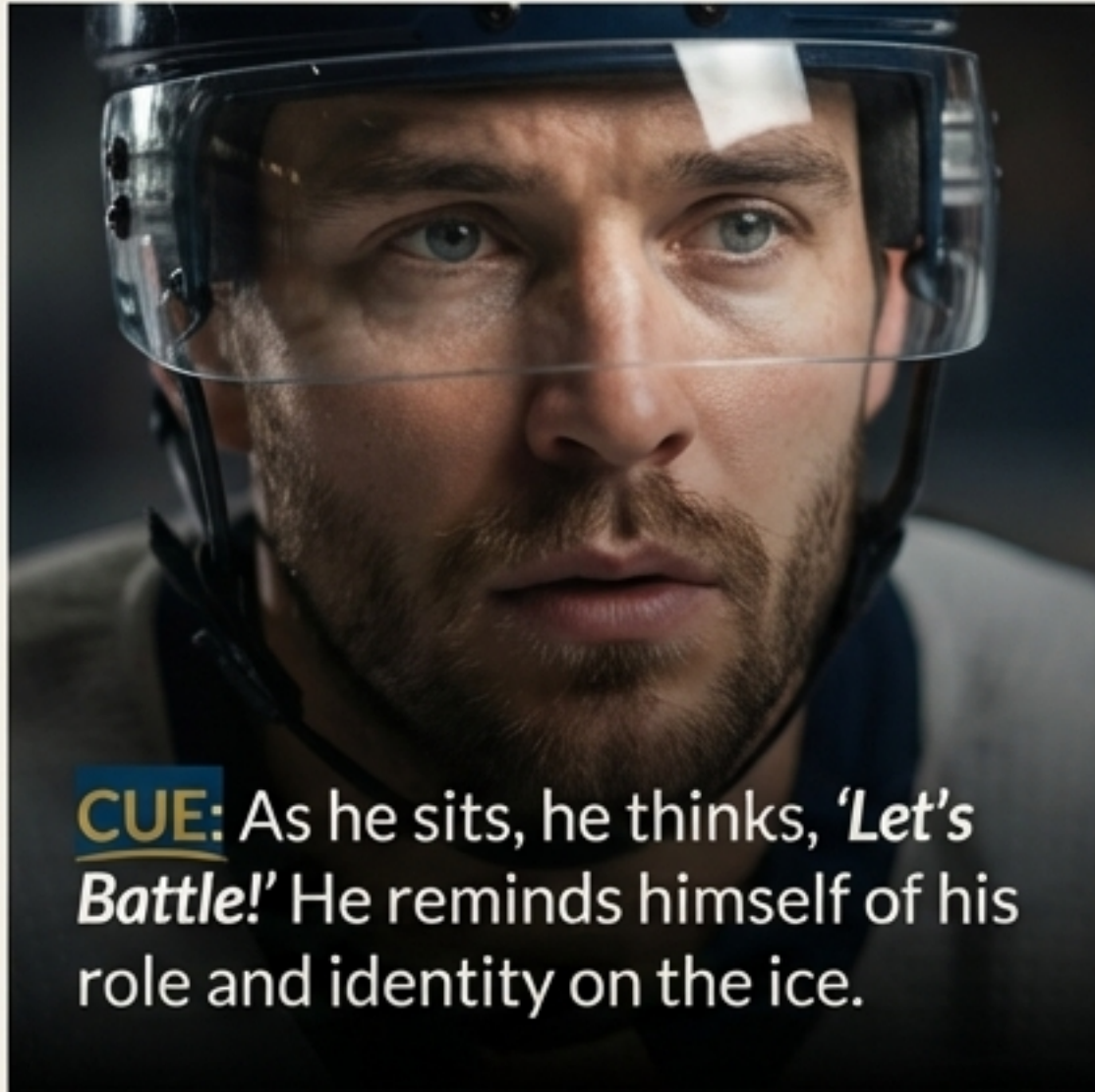
Source Insight

➤ *"From a neuroscience point of view, being totally focused means the brain structures that are essential for performing a task are fully engaged and those structures that are not engaged drop out." (Hatfield & Kerrick)*

Examples of External Targets

- **The Pitcher:** The catcher's mitt.
- **The Speaker:** A friendly face in the front row.
- **The Surgeon:** The point of the first incision.

C-B-A in Action: The Between-Shift Reset



Result: He steps back onto the ice not just physically rested, but mentally primed and fully engaged in the present moment.

C-B-A in Action: Finding Certainty in Chaos

Scenario

Captain Stoney Portis in a helicopter, flying into an active firefight to lead his soldiers.

CUE

He counters the thought "This is how I'm going to die" with his affirmation: **"I am the leader; I make the decisions when it counts."**

BREATHE

He consciously slows down his breathing to calm the natural flood of adrenaline and fear, winning one small First Victory at a time.

ATTACH

He attaches his attention to the immediate plan: **"I pictured exactly where we would land and exactly what each of us would do once we hit the ground."**

"Before I knew it, I was completely relaxed and in my zone."



Your Turn: Design Your Pre-Performance Routine



CUE Your Conviction

What is the one truth about yourself you need to hear right before you perform?

Guidance: Write it in the first person ("I...") and the present tense ("I am...").

My Affirmation: _____



BREATHE Your Body

What breathing pattern centers and calms you?

Guidance: A simple rhythm like a 4-second inhale and 6-second exhale can trigger relaxation.

My Rhythm: _____



ATTACH Your Attention

What is your "spotlight"? The one external target that signals it's time to go?

Guidance: This should be something you can see, hear, or feel outside of yourself.

My Target: _____

Win First, Then Go to War

Key Takeaway

The battle for peak performance is won or lost in the moments before it begins. Your pre-performance routine is not a superstition; it is a strategic weapon. By mastering the transition, you ensure the confidence you have built is the confidence you can use. This is your First Victory.

“Victorious warriors win first and then go to war, while defeated warriors go to war first and then seek to win.” — Sun Tzu

